



COLUMBIA UNIVERSITY
IN THE CITY OF NEW YORK

Sammy Abdella

sn3136@columbia.edu

345 W 86th Street, New York, NY, 10024

Dear Mr. Pichai,

It's a genuine honor to reach out to you, especially through Mrs. Jane Sun, to whom I'm grateful for the care she has shown me. I'm writing to you as a fellow international student, because your story has long been a beacon of hope in our community.

As you once wrote, "America provided access to opportunities that simply didn't exist for many of us before we arrived." I realized the weight of that idea at 18, as I was facing the death penalty in Tunisia after my parents outed me as gay, which is criminalized there. I worked as a server and cleaned bathrooms so that I could afford access to public libraries. There, I taught myself English and used the public computers to apply to Columbia University. I escaped to the United States as an international student with only the clothes on my back, and in two months, I will graduate from Columbia University with a Bachelor's degree in Computer Science.

With years of experience including AI research and internships at YC funded AI companies, I'm ready to devote my life to Google's mission and to the belief that the best technology expands opportunity for everyone, not only those born near it. As you have emphasized, immigration has helped build America's technology leadership, and immigrants have made a "phenomenal" contribution to the sector. Your own path from international student to building your career in the United States is living proof of what opportunity can unlock.

However, at this moment, my biggest barrier isn't ambition or readiness. It's my immigration status and the need for H1B sponsorship. I'm unable to renew my Tunisian passport due to my persecution in Tunisia, and asylum cases in the USA are currently frozen indefinitely. Therefore, my last hope remains to stay in the USA, as my departure would forfeit my right to return.

When you have spoken about the H1B program and the "phenomenal contribution" immigrants make, I felt seen. I hope to be given the chance to devote my life to making phenomenal contributions at Google. If given that chance, I will honor it with the same perseverance that carried me from the Tunisian public library to Columbia, and I will repay it by building systems that are worthy of the trust users place in Google.

With utmost respect and gratitude,

Sam Nawaly Abdella

Sammy Abdella

sn3136@columbia.edu - 484-403-6476

EDUCATION

Columbia University in The City of New York

B.S. Computer Science

SKILLS

Technical: Python, Git, Linux, REST, PostgreSQL, C++, Java, JavaScript, SQL, HTML/CSS, Ruby, OAuth2, JWT, Docker, Kubernetes

Languages: French, Arabic, English

EXPERIENCE

Web Developer Intern | Columbia College IT Dept | New York, NY

08/2025 – Present

- Migrated 43 Columbia departmental websites from Drupal 7 to Drupal 10, writing migration scripts, refactoring custom modules, building/refreshing site themes with HTML/CSS, running regression tests, improving average page load times by ~35%, and removing 100% of deprecated modules in production
- Integrated a Django, PostgreSQL, and RESTful API backend with a new Columbia admissions website, scaling reliably to 50,000+ applicants per cycle, cutting form submission errors by ~40%, and reducing manual data correction work by ~50%

Backend Software Developer Intern | Casca | Remote

06/2024 – 09/2024

- Built async webhook pipeline with Celery/Redis, reducing settlement processing lag ~25% and cutting duplicate payout incidents by 70% through idempotency and retry controls
- Implemented OpenTelemetry tracing and structured logging across services; shortened incident triage time ~30% and improved root-cause identification during outages for on-call engineers
- Strengthened transaction services with RBAC, audit trails, and secrets rotation; reduced unauthorized-access alerts ~15%, improved audit readiness, and made large deployments more reliable under peak traffic

Research Intern | Columbia University AI Laboratory | New York, NY

01/2025 – 09/2025

- Led the development for gAyl, an AI tool for LGBTQ+ suicide prevention, designed six model-based safety benchmarks to generate treatment plan recommendations and achieved <15% false-negative rate on unsafe-response detection across 1,000+ high-risk prompts
- Trained LLM-based classifiers in PyTorch and Hugging Face Transformers to automate safety evaluation, reducing manual benchmarking time by ~95%
- Publication (co-author): <https://doi.org/10.7916/z6vc-d867>

Software Engineer Intern | Compyle.ai | Remote

05/2025 – Present

- Added Sentry error monitoring and alerts for the summarization/Q&A pipeline; reduced time-to-detect production errors by ~60% and cut repeat-user failure reports by ~20%
- Implemented request throttling and caching for LLM calls using Redis; reduced average LLM API requests per user session by ~30% and lowered latency spikes during peak usage

Projects

AI-Powered Exam Tutor | Python, Django, PostgreSQL, Redis, Celery, Docker

09/2025 – 01/2026

- Built a web app that generates timed practice exams, stores attempts, and produces graded reports with explanations and targeted remediation suggestions
- Deployed with Columbia University's Learning Center to support 50+ students across Data Structures, Advanced Programming, and Multivariable Calculus exam prep